

How to be dry, wet or dampish

Continued from Living 1

caused by people who don't wear ties: 80 per cent.

14. Hair is a good indication. How much attention does it get? Is the color natural? Does it have the perfect frenzy of a squashed bird's nest in the convincing fashion of Mrs Renouf? 95 per cent.

15. You think the country would go ahead with magnificent assurance if most trade unions were abolished and their leaders jailed: .02 per cent.

16. You think the country would go ahead with magnificent assurance if all companies made employees majority shareholders and appointed union men to positions on the board: 92 per cent.

If your average humidity reading is under 20 per cent you are right for eminence in the Liberal Party. If you can score under 10 Mr Howard might even admit you to his shadowy inner-Cabinet.

For me, I am still unsure. I am wallowing at around 50 per cent. But just you wait and see. Things will not remain this way. Any week from now a new group will emerge, the Centre Faction, no doubt led by Mr Hodgman.

I guess they will be called the "moists". — Keith Dunstan

Robust daughter born to Grange: both well

By STEPHEN DOWNES

IF THESE pages were green and appearing on a Thursday, you would be forgiven for thinking that 'Daughter of Grange' was yet another squalid spin-off from 'Dallas'.

But it isn't, and any reference to an offspring of Grange is, for people who love wine, all about an important new red wine from Penfolds.

Using its Ultimate Dinner Party 1985 as the slipway, the big Adelaide wine company launched its Magill Estate 1983 on Saturday night amid 130 appreciative, formally dressed representatives of the media and the trade.

The new wine has an engaging history. In splendidly verdant foothills about a dozen or so kilometres outside the city, Penfolds' Magill property was a sight-unseen acquisition of Dr Rawson Penfold of Devon more than 140 years ago. With his wife, he settled there in 1844 and vines were planted.

Dr Penfold died not so many years after arriving in Australia, but Mrs Penfold ruled the vineyard in tyrannical style from the wide front veranda of the family cottage, which her maidservant is said to haunt these days.

With a small bell, she would alert the grape-pickers' foreman to men she thought were slacking.

Having done it once too often one day, she was given a bare-faced message; the pickers turned their backs on her, dropped their trousers and bent over.

Farther up the hill from the cottage, a great and beautiful stone winery was being established where fermentation in huge open vats continued until quite recent years.

Then there was a lapse — Penfolds moved fermentation to Nuriootpa and used Magill only for maturation.

Parts of the Magill plantings became, according to the company, uneconomic. In recent years they have been sold off for housing subdivisions. (Environmentalists and several Adelaide wine-writers unsuccessfully fought the sale. Penfolds claim that the vines they ripped up were being used only for white wines and not their classic reds.)

So, by the early eighties, Penfolds had only a handful of hectares of century-old shiraz left at Magill: this constituted a ticklish problem. With a fine new wine and an unexceptionable marketing strategy they have solved it.

Launching the new Magill Estate, managing director Ian Mackley said the "Daughter of Grange" came from "the finest piece of vineyard in the whole Adelaide area". The old vines were being picked again, and the



The new prestige Penfolds: almost three times rarer than Grange.

old fermentation vats were being filled with their fruit. Only about 1400 cases of the wine could be made each year, and each bottle would carry Grange Hermitage's premium price of about \$28.

Mr Mackley finished his speech; we sniffed and sipped a very fine red which has been developed assiduously by Penfolds' great grey

eminence Max Schubert and chief winemaker Don Ditter to produce characteristic richness, excellent balance and big fruit. The wine will be retailed later in the year in numbered bottles.

A wine expert told me it was a remarkable wine to come out of the 1983 vintage. The French oak

in which it had been matured was well-integrated, it had quite a lot of acid and would probably be at its best in four or so years. Was it too expensive? Yes, but it was also very rare.

I was impressed by the company's courage in announcing it to the media in such circumstances.

Penfolds held its first Ultimate Dinner Party in 1983 to celebrate the 25th consecutive release of Grange Hermitage. At each of the annual "ultimates" since — if that's not a contradiction — great Granges have been drunk.

Saturday was no exception, the 1971 vintage, which Max Schubert had told several of us earlier in the day was his best, being simply astonishing in the fullness of its flavor, balance and body. For those who don't remember, it was, after all, placed first in its category at Gault et Millau's Wine Olympics in Paris in 1979.

Among several other highly distinguished wines during six hours at the table, we were served a luscious 1982 Bin 707 cabernet and a fruity Oloroso sherry with a desert-dry finish that Max Schubert has been blending on and off over the past few years to complement delicate consommés.

Served in The Grange restaurant of the Adelaide Hilton, the banquet was prepared by executive chefs from the five Hiltons around Australia. Bearing in mind

the constraints of serving scores of diners at once, every dish showed high skill in the kitchen.

We ate avocado with a crab-meat mousse, quail consommé with tiny truffle dumplings (more dumpling than truffle), medallions of mutton, an excellent Western Australian freshwater lobster with a good, gelatinous texture, with a trellis of john dory and trout, smoked lamb noisettes with morels and chanterelles, a wonderful green salad composed of 10 elements and exceptional strawberries with a rhubarb sabayon and grand marnier cream.

I found that the earlier dishes, though technically well executed, lacked the stronger tastes I lean towards. The consommé, for instance, could have been a degree or more richer, as might have been the watercress and marjoram sauces with the mutton-fish dish and the lamb. But delicacy is fashionable in modern cuisine, and to send a diner's palate out on the chase after subtlety is seen to be acceptable among most chefs these days.

So the highlight for me was a grilled fresh chevre, which was served with the '71 Grange. To fall back on a totally apposite cliché, they were made for each other.

Stephen Downes was a guest of Penfolds, Hilton International Australia and TAA.

Touring the city

Continued from Living 4

arches, or the hectic little cafes with red lacquer ducks twirling in the windows.

It was the Sum Kum Lee building, commissioned by a prominent Chinese merchant who plainly wanted something of everything. The warehouse and residence were completed in 1887 in classic boom-style, occupying a very small space but bristling with columns and shapes, triangles and stripes. The Numpoonson Chinese Society Club House, farther back at number 202, was built in 1882. Its purpose was more practical: a club and temporary accommodation centre. Behind the dormitory lay an opium-smoking den.

The last stop on the walk was Gordon House, at the top of the city near Spring Street. It is a discreet fortress built by the philanthropist William Coppin, said the brochure, to provide decent lodgings for the poor. Now the rich have taken it over and tastefully renovated it providing luxury accommodation, gourmet food and up-market business tenants. Brick paving and green trees in pots set it neatly in place. This is the way modern Victoria likes to show history. We clean it up, like Carlton, and at the same time distort it. The National Trust has prepared a set of six Rediscove Melbourne walks to celebrate Melbourne's 150th anniversary. You can buy the set for \$2 at any National Trust outlet. Telephone 654 4711 for information.

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Guide winners

Readers found 'The Age' Good Food Guide Quiz much more difficult this year — so difficult in fact that only six people gave the correct answers to all seven questions.

The correct answers were:
1 (b) James Beard said: "A gourmet who thinks of calories is like a tart who looks at her watch."

2 (a) If you came across cilantro in a restaurant, you would eat it. Cilantro is another name for coriander, which is also known as Chinese parsley.

3 (b) Mad apple was a name once given to egg-plant.

4 (c) Balsamic vinegar is an aged vinegar which is a specialty of the Italian city of Modena.

5 (a) Konbu, an ingredient in Japanese cooking, is dried kelp.

6 (c) Pig-in-the-middle is the odd one out. Spotted dick and toad-in-the-hole are both things to eat; pig-in-the-middle is a game.

7 (a) Zakuski are Russian hors d'oeuvres. Questions 1 and 3 proved the trickiest for entrants.

The six winners who will receive a free copy of the sixth edition of 'The Age' Good Food Guide' are:

Flora Skiotis (Elwood), P. F. Thompson (Forest Hill), Bob Sanders (Mt Waverley), Alicja Lipska (Rowville), A. Simon (Boronia), D. W. Taylor (Heidelberg West).

But it was decided to award the remaining free copies to the first 14 nearly correct entries, that is, the first 14 we opened which had six out of seven answers correct.

They were: Mrs W. Freeman (Mooroolbark), F. McGrath (Warragul), D. Pittcock (Elsternwick), P. Hains (Boronia), Rodney Fernald (Bulleen), Robert Woollen (Daylesford), Kerry Sullivan (Blackburn South), M. Robins (Surrey Hills), G. Woolley (Notting Hill), Elise Dott (Williamstown), S. Wisnia (West Brunswick), D. Allen (Mt Waverley), Mrs R. Stevens (Heidelberg) and Alan Vickery (Blackburn South).

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City seating

Cont from Living 1

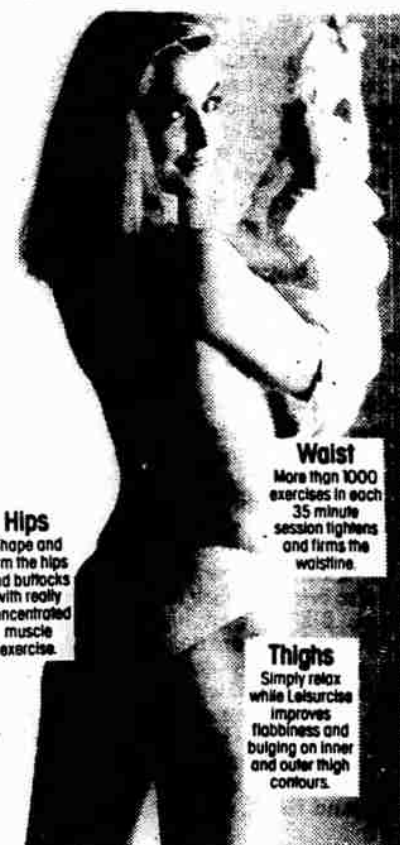
they offer the perfect spot to "just sit" (thinking is optional) and admire the beauty of William Guilfoyle's masterpiece.

Vine-shaded seating arbors, so popular with Victorian ladies protecting their English-rose complexions, have fallen into disfavor (and disrepair) with the advent of today's sun-worshipper. But there are plans to upgrade them for history's sake.

The latest addition to the gardens' seating are three handcrafted seats with high backs and turned arms that have been donated (and appropriately plaqued) by generous organisations.

"Actually there has never been a problem with seating in the gardens," according to Mr Arnold Clarke, its administration officer. "Most people prefer to sit on the grass." Who could blame them?

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Musee, Nicolas. Claude Monet. Gelatin-silver print, (24.3 x 19.3cm) collection, The Museum of Modern Art, New York. Gift of Mrs. Nicolas Muray.

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